Blown Sideways Through Life

By Claudia Shear

CLAUDIA: (Pg 1-4) It's 3 o'clock and I'm sitting on a bench putting on a pair of cop shoes . . . It's Wednesday at 11 A.M. and I'm pulling on thick janitor's gloves and picking up a bucket. . . It's 4:15 in the morning and I'm trying to take a nap in a bathroom on Wall Street by balancing my head on the toilet-paper roll. . . I fasten on a phone headset. . . .

And then I carry up cases of beer, tubs of chicken, stacks of documents, flats of eggs, trays of lipsticks. I set up the computer, the desk, the stock. I read the documents, chop the onions, wash the walls, wash the dishes, answer the phone, answer the phone, answer the phone. *(answering phones)*

- "Good afternoon, Battle, Fowler, Jaffin and Kheel. . . "
- "Good morning, Shakespeare Festival. . ."
- "***Buona sera,*** Le Madri. . . "
- "Medical Center Patient Information, what room, please?"

And they tell me . . . *(various boss voices)*

- "Chill on the conversation."
- "Be nice to the customers!"
- "Put your book away! No reading allowed!"
- "Here's a club in case they come to rob the restaurant when I'm not here."
- "Remember to always give your name."
- "Never give your name!"

And then, later, I hear, *(various boss voices)*

- "Uh, there's been complaints about your attitude."
- "You were heard whistling in the elevator. . . "
- ". . . singing in the dining room . . ."
- "You talk too much . . ."

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- "Your laugh is too loud. . . "
- "No standing around! Look busy!"

And my personal favorite: "I don't have to give you a reason. It's ***my*** restaurant!"

And finally: *(various boss voices)*

- "Listen, we're going to have to let you go. . . "
- "Oh, this is your last shift."
- "Well, it's my way or the highway."
- "You're fired!"

And every time I just say, *(with growing frustration)* "All right, all right, all right."

INTRODUCTION

If life were a stable career path, Claudia Shear didn't just miss the memo; she used it to light a cigarette on her way out of yet another job. Ricocheting between gigs like a human pinball, she hustles through it all with a world-class eye-roll and absolutely no illusion of job security.

And then . . . she found waitressing. The glamorous arena where "May I take your order, madam?" really means "Please don't emotionally unravel over the soup of the day."

It's a chaotic parade of low-wage survival jobs where dignity is optional, sanity is negotiable, and every shift feels like a social experiment. But don't worry, customers -- Claudia's got a few tips to help you behave like a decent human while the waiters and waitresses talk about you behind your back.

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CLAUDIA: **(Pg 5-6)** I'm from Brooklyn. Enthralled by the incredible glamour of the bad kid, I tried to keep up, running from cop cars with the friends I carefully chose -- girls like Janine Morelli, who was mean and punched me like a boy -- or hanging out in a park on Avenue P. Oh, God, did I want "in." In with Kathleen and Debby and Ronnie, skinny girls in shiny fabrics who bit their nails and painted them anyway.

We were tough. We "hung out." [But] I was a prime target. God knows how they knew I was different. I smoked and cursed and fought and stuffed my bra with tissues. But the part of me that still believed in Narnia and cried for Black Beauty must have somehow given me away.

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(Pg 8) Back in my basement in Brooklyn I read books that ranged from *The Divine Comedy* to Book-of-the-Month Club selections of the late 1950s. I read anything I could get my hands on. A misfit in Flatbush, I wanted out so badly, I wanted to fit in so much

(Pg 10-11) Inside my head there was romance: running through the Highlands with Alan Breck, Crusoe on a desert island, atop a magic mountain, astride a horse with wings. I wanted adventure. A cottage in the woods with the enchanted sword. The search for the Holy Grail. The trials of the hero. All for the quest! Inside my head I was suffering and striving in great feats of strength and ennobling tests of character. This was the plan of my life, the concept perfectly framed.

But what actually was my life?

At last count I've had 65 jobs, and some of them of unusually short duration, the briefest being at a restaurant called Bar Lui: Got hired. Went to work. Drank an iced coffee. Made a few phone calls. After about 10 minutes the manager interrupted me.

MANAGER: Um, we have very specific policies regarding personal calls. . .

CLAUDIA: *(to manager)* Oh, ***please***! You must be kidding. *(to audience)* So I got my coat, got my keys, my token, my ticket, my passport, my cash card, and I hit the road, Jack. Out the door on a subway, a train, a plane, a bus. Walking to an address, a comer, a park, a bar, life can spin on a dime. *(beat)*

(Pg 31) Waitering. What a way to make a living. It's prison, voluntary incarceration, as we line up in the kitchen at 3 P.M. for the "family meal," pushing our trays along, food dumped on our plate at each station. One of the waiters jokingly asks for "a breast, please, Warden!" and the line of guys in white shirts and ties, order books in breast pockets, shout with laughter. I am the only woman.

(Pg 32-33) Aspiring actors work alongside people who are supporting families alongside dedicated party animals who love the hours and the cash. Unusual people waiter. My friend Bill, a young actor, worked in a French restaurant. One night, while waiting at the bar, he overheard Barbara, the bartender, ask one of the other waiters, a French guy named Pierre,

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to get her some milk from the kitchen for a cocktail.

PIERRE: *(with a panicked expression)* Oh, Please. No!

BARBARA: What? I'm swamped. Just get me some milk!

PIERRE: *(shaking his head)* I am so sorry, Barbara, but I really cannot. *(backing away)*

BARBARA: Will someone please tell me what is going on?

ANOTHER WAITER: Well, Pierre, he has a problem. He is scared of milk. He cannot touch milk. It makes him afraid to be near it.

BARBARA: *(laughing)* Scared of milk?

ANOTHER WAITER: It is serious. He truly has fear of milk ... and carrots.

CLAUDIA: **(Pg 35 - 37)** Out on the floor it's the front lines, it's a war, and the waiters are caught between two flanks -- customer and management. Comrades-in-arms, we share a look across a table, shield each other from the manager as we surreptitiously pry a broken cork out of a wine bottle. We are in this together. We lean against a wall and engage in "waiter conversation": two people side by side but never looking at each other, mouths hardly moving, eyes scanning the room for the lift of a beckoning hand. You are expendable, the smallest slip can lead to the freefall of unemployment. Survival is all.

Tips for Waiters

1. **Wear cop shoes.** As a waiter your entire consciousness is centered in your feet. Cop shoes are strong, cheap, and give you a certain clomping authority.
3. **Get retractable pens**. You'll lose the top to any other kind, get Rorschach stains on your uniform shirt, and your manager will force you to buy a new one.
4. **Get the best busboy.** Bribe him if you must.
5. **Avoid the VIP tables**. Waiting on Warren Beatty is far more trouble than it's worth. At first it's kind of a thrill, but then it's just another table that wants more water and bread, wants to hear the "specials" again, only worse, because the manager is breathing down your neck, dying for an excuse to meet a star.

Tips for Customers

1. **Never touch the waiter.** Even if you think you are being nice, that you have a great

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rapport, think how shocking it would be if the waiter touched *you.*

2. **Don't ask personal questions.** I've been asked questions by customers that even my mother wouldn't ask me.
3. **Order dinner without commentary.** We aren't interested if you like chicken, hate carrots, never eat white flour. Simply tell us what you want.
4. **Finish chewing before you talk to the waiter.** We'll wait. Really.
5. **Don't snap your fingers.**
6. **Don't call the busperson "Pedro" or "Ahmed" or "Consuelo."** Or any other name you think might be his or hers because of nationality.
7. **Don't mention the tip.** As in "Listen, take good care of us and you'll get a really good tip."
8. **Don't complain to the manager.** Restaurants are tough places, so know that if you complain, it means the subject of your criticism will be fired. FIRED. Out the door.

(Pg 4) *(various boss voices)*

- "Listen, we're going to have to let you go. . . "
- "Oh, this is your last shift."
- "Well, it's my way or the highway."
- "You're fired!"

CLAUDIA: *(with growing frustration)* "All right, all right, all right."

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
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